CHAPTER 3

ALL-ROUNDER

The Internet is a fantastic platform for information that has changed the world and empowered billions of people. It is also a place where complete falsehoods and exaggerations can be authoritatively presented as fact and repeated and repeated and repeated to a point where they effectively become 'facts'.

Sky Sports has rightly become one of the most respected sports news organisations and, on 28 February 2015, during the build-up to the 2015 Cricket World Cup, an online article was published on the Sky Sports website describing me as 'cricket's record-breaking all-rounder' listing various achievements.

It appeared – and still appears – on a trusted website, so it must be true.

Right?

'De Villiers was shortlisted for the South African national hockey squad,' the article says.

True or false?

False.

In truth, I played hockey for one year at high school and was a member of the Afrikaanse Hoër Seunskool Under-16A team that beat our near neighbours and rivals at Pretoria Boys' High for the first time, but I was never shortlisted for the national hockey squad, or ever came remotely close to that level.